

Braxton Hicks contractions

One of the most common symptoms of approaching labor is an increase in the strength and frequency of Braxton Hicks, or practice, contractions (see [False labor](#)), which may be occurring up to four times an hour. The purpose of these practice contractions is to prepare your uterus to deal with real labor contractions so that labor progresses smoothly. Some women find Braxton Hicks relatively painless, while others find these practice contractions fairly uncomfortable, especially if the baby is quite low and contractions cause increased pelvic pressure.

Apart from the level of pain, one of the main ways to distinguish Braxton Hicks from real contractions is that Braxton Hicks are irregular and they fade away, whereas labor pains occur at regular intervals and gradually become stronger, more intense, and closer together. The other main difference between Braxton Hicks contractions and real ones is that, unlike Braxton Hicks, real contractions cause your cervix to dilate, which indicates that labor is beginning.

Engagement of the head

With a first baby, dropping down of the baby's head into your pelvis, known as engagement, usually means that labor is likely to start soon. In second and subsequent pregnancies, engagement may not occur until the start of labor.

You can usually tell that your baby's position has changed in two ways. First, you may notice that you have less discomfort in your upper abdomen or around your ribs because the downward movement releases some pressure. Second, you may notice increased pressure or pain in your pelvic or vaginal area as the baby's head moves into position. Your walking may become more of a waddle and you may have to use the bathroom more frequently than before. In some cases, your baby's head may pinch some of the nerves that run through your pelvis and you may experience [sciatica](#), a sharp electric pain that runs down the outside of your leg to your outside toes.

A NATURAL OCCURRENCE

No one is sure exactly what triggers labor, but it seems the process varies with each species. In sheep, a drop in progesterone signals the start of labor. In mice, babies release proteins to signal their maturity. In humans, little is known about the signals that start labor, although there are many theories. Studies suggest that the production of hormones such as corticotrophin-releasing hormone (CRH) by the uterus and placenta may play a role. It's also thought that an increase in pro-inflammatory substances known as cytokines may be involved. Whatever the trigger, it's likely that the onset of labor involves a biological communication between your baby and your body.

SIGNS OF APPROACHING LABOR

Although each woman's experience of labor differs and there are no hard and fast rules as to what will happen when, there are signs that indicate that labor is likely to start either imminently or within a matter of days. One of the classic signs that labor isn't far away is a "[bloody show](#)," when you lose the plug of mucus that has protected your baby during pregnancy. The other indisputable sign that labor will be shortly underway is that your cervix begins to dilate, although of course this will only be visible during an internal examination.

One other sign that labor may be about to start is if your [water breaks](#). However, for the majority of women this happens later on during established labor.